

Mastering File Paths

A Comprehensive Guide to Computer & HTML Navigation

1. What is a File Path?

A file path is the "address" of a file or folder on a computer or web server. It tells the operating system or the browser exactly where to look for a specific resource.

2. Absolute vs. Relative Paths

Absolute Paths

An absolute path provides the **full address** from the very root of the file system. It is independent of where the current file is located.

- **Windows:** `C:\Users\Name\Documents\image.jpg`
- **Web/URL:** `https://www.example.com/images/logo.png`

Relative Paths

A relative path points to a file **in relation to** the current directory. This is the gold standard for web development because it keeps links working even if you move the entire project folder to a different drive or server.

3. Navigation Syntax in HTML

When writing HTML, you use specific symbols to move through folders:

Syntax	Meaning	Example
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<code>filename.html</code>	The file is in the same folder as the current page.	<code></code>
<code>folder/ file.jpg</code>	Move down into a subfolder.	<code></code>
<code>../file.css</code>	Move up one level (out of the current folder).	<code><link href="../ style.css"></code>
<code>/</code>	Go to the root directory of the website.	<code></code>

4. Practical Scenario

Imagine your project looks like this:

```
Project Folder/
├─ index.html
├─ styles/
│   └─ style.css
└─ assets/
    └─ images/
        └─ logo.png
```

To link the image inside `index.html` :

```

```

To link the CSS file inside `index.html` :

```
<link rel="stylesheet" href="styles/style.css">
```

Pro-Tip for Portfolios: Always use **Relative Paths** (like `images/pic.png`) instead of Absolute Paths (like `C:/Users/Desktop/pic.png`). If you use an

absolute path from your computer, the image will break the moment you upload your website to the internet!

5. Common Mistakes

- **Case Sensitivity:** Most web servers (Linux-based) treat `Logo.png` and `logo.png` as different files. Always use lowercase for consistency.
- **Backslashes vs. Forward Slashes:** Windows uses `\`, but the Web and HTML use `/`. Always use forward slashes in your code.
- **Spaces:** Avoid spaces in file names (e.g., use `my-image.jpg` instead of `my image.jpg`).